

Wild and safe: On growing human-wildlife conflict

Habitat fragmentation has led to rise in human-wildlife conflict

Recent human **fatalities** due to wild animal attacks, deep inside forests, in **forest-fringed** human habitations, and even within villages, **have highlighted** growing human-wildlife conflict in Kerala, where nearly 29% of the land is forested. With a **dry spell** and an unusually hot summer expected, urgent measures are needed to prevent further **escalation** of this conflict, which now has political, social, and environmental **dimensions**. The Kerala government is facing **criticism** for its **perceived** inability to manage wildlife. **Groups** such as the Kerala Independent Farmers' Association (KIFA) and sections of the church **advocate** for culling wildlife, **citing** an **alleged** population boom. However, Forest Department data suggest otherwise. The wild elephant **population**, linked to 18% of human **fatalities**, **has** declined by 7%. **Snakebites**, responsible for 75% of wildlife-related deaths, **have** fallen from 113 in 2012 to 34 in 2023. Overall, human **deaths** from wildlife **encounters** **have** decreased from 146 in 2018 to 57 last year. Yet, this is no cause for **complacency**. A **concerning** trend is that many victims are from tribal communities, traditionally **adept at coexisting** with wildlife. The government should investigate this as part of its newly announced mission to document and **assess** the traditional knowledge of Kerala's 36 tribal communities in tackling wildlife encounters.

There are also several **anthropogenic** factors. **Habitat fragmentation**, particularly in elephant corridors such as Aralam Farm (Kannur) and Chinnakkanal (Idukki), **has** forced animals into human settlements. Unregulated tourism, cattle **grazing** near forests, **encroachments**, and food waste **dumping** on forest **fringes** further **exacerbate** the issue. **Invasive** plants (*Senna spectabilis*) and monoculture industrial plantations have also **disrupted** wildlife feeding patterns. In response, the Kerala government, in 2022, **empowered** local bodies to **eliminate** feral wild boars damaging farmland. Last year, the Cabinet classified human-wildlife conflict as a State-specific disaster, allowing the Disaster Management Authority to intervene. The government's **decision** to **emphasise** participatory forest and wildlife management **is a step in the right direction**, **given** the extreme views **propagated** by some sections. The Forest Department has **restored** 5,031 hectares of natural forest and built ponds and check dams. However, **restoring** areas dominated by industrial plantations such as eucalyptus and acacia **is** a challenge. While solar fencing has shown some success, the ₹52-crore elephant-proof wall at Aralam, one of 12 conflict **landscapes**, remains incomplete. The State's 10 **missions** to **mitigate** human-wildlife conflict **must** be prioritised. Given the region-specific nature of the problem, a multi-agency **approach** involving the Disaster Management, Revenue, Local Self-Government, Tribal Welfare, Agriculture, Health and Forest Departments **is** crucial to balancing human safety and **sustainable** wildlife management. [Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

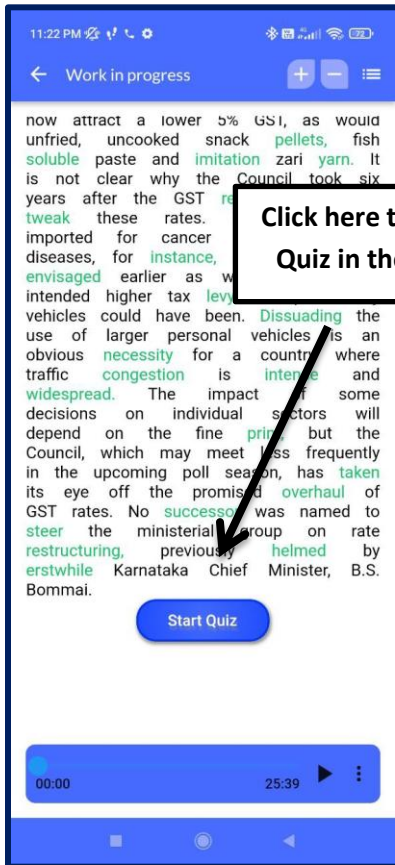
1. **Habitat Fragmentation** (noun) – the process of breaking large habitats into smaller, isolated pieces
2. **Lead** (to) (verb) – Result in, Cause, Bring about, Trigger, Produce वजह बनना
3. **Fatality** (noun) – Death, Casualty, Loss, Mortality, Demise मृत्यु
4. **Forest-fringed** (adjective) – Forest-edged, Forest-bordered, Forest-surrounded, Forest-lined, Forest-adjacent जंगल से घिरा
5. **Highlight** (verb) – Emphasize, Spotlight, Accentuate, Showcase, Feature जोर देना
6. **Dry spell** (noun) – Drought, Dry period, Aridity, Water shortage, Scarcity सूखा
7. **Escalation** (noun) – Increase, Rise, Intensification, Surge, Growth वृद्धि
8. **Dimension** (noun) – Aspect, Factor, Element, Feature, Perspective पहलू/ आयाम
9. **Criticism** (noun) – Disapproval, Censure, Condemnation, Reproach, Blame आलोचना
10. **Perceived** (adjective) – Seen, Recognized, Understood, Apparent, Observed माना गया
11. **Advocate** (verb) – Support, Promote, Champion, Endorse, Back समर्थन करना
12. **Cite** (verb) – Mention, Refer to, Quote, Point out, Name हवाला देना
13. **Alleged** (adjective) – Supposed, Claimed, Purported, Reported, Accused कथित
14. **Encounter** (noun) – Meeting, Confrontation, Interaction, Clash, Experience मुठभेड़
15. **Complacency** (noun) – Self-satisfaction, Smugness, Overconfidence, Satisfaction, Indifference आत्मसंतुष्टि
16. **Concerning** (adjective) – Worrying, Disturbing, Troubling, Alarming, Disconcerting चिंताजनक
17. **Adept** (at) (adjective) – Skilled, Proficient, Expert, Competent, Capable निपुण
18. **Coexist** (verb) – Live together, Cohabit, Co-occur, Co-reside, Harmonize सह-अस्तित्व
19. **Assess** (verb) – Evaluate, Analyze, Judge, Appraise, Review मूल्यांकन करना
20. **Anthropogenic** (adjective) – Human-caused, Man-made, Artificial, Human-induced, Synthetic मानवजनित
21. **Graze** (verb) – Feed, Browse, Pasture, Forage, Nibble चरना
22. **Encroachment** (noun) – Intrusion, Invasion, Infringement, Trespass, Overreach अतिक्रमण
23. **Dumping** (noun) – Disposal, Discarding, Discharge, Throwing, Unloading फेंकना

24. **Fringe** (noun) – Edge, Border, Margin, Perimeter, Boundary किनारा
25. **Exacerbate** (verb) – Worsen, Aggravate, Intensify, Heighten, Increase बढ़ाना
26. **Invasive** (adjective) – Intrusive, Aggressive, Spreading, Encroaching, Dominant आक्रामक
27. **Disrupt** (verb) – Disturb, Interrupt, Break, Hinder, Upset बाधित करना
28. **Empower** (verb) – Enable, Authorize, Strengthen, Encourage, Support सशक्त करना
29. **Eliminate** (verb) – Remove, Eradicate, Abolish, Erase, Exclude खत्म करना
30. **Feral** (adjective) – Wild, Untamed, Savage, Uncontrolled, Ferocious जंगली
31. **Emphasise** (verb) – Highlight, Stress, Accentuate, Underline, Focus जोर देना
32. **A Step in the right direction** (phrase) – Positive move, Progress, Improvement, Advancement, Forward step सही दिशा में कदम
33. **Given** (preposition) – Considering, Taking into account, In view of, Bearing in mind, Regarding देखते हुए
34. **Propagate** (verb) – Spread, Promote, Disseminate, Circulate, Broadcast प्रसारित करना
35. **Restore** (verb) – Rebuild, Repair, Renew, Reconstruct, Revive पुनर्स्थापित करना
36. **Landscape** (noun) – Terrain, Scenery, Environment, Topography, Setting परिदृश्य
37. **Mitigate** (verb) – Alleviate, Reduce, Lessen, Ease, Diminish कम करना
38. **Sustainable** (adjective) – Eco-friendly, Renewable, Viable, Enduring, Balanced टिकाऊ

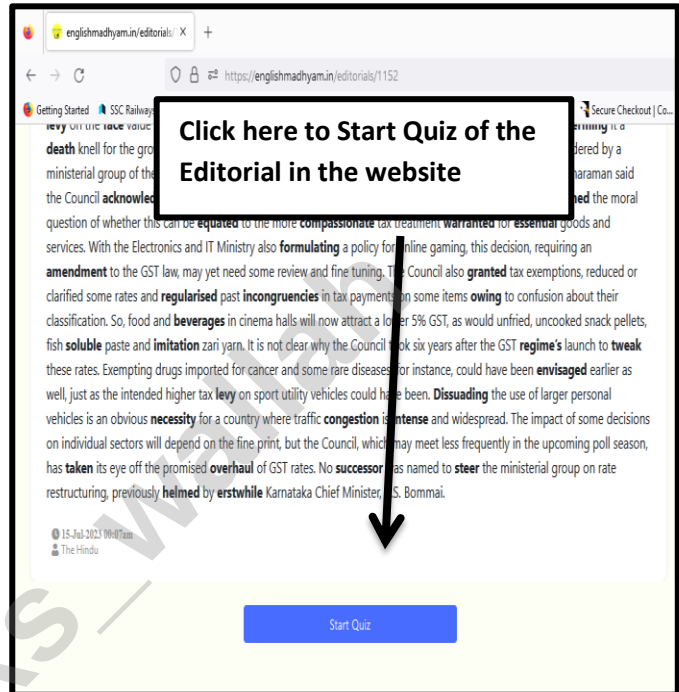
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Rising Human-Wildlife Conflict:** Kerala faces increasing human-wildlife conflicts, with fatalities occurring in forests, forest-fringed areas, and villages.
2. **Forest Coverage:** Nearly 29% of Kerala's land is forested, contributing to frequent wildlife encounters.
3. **Climate Impact:** An expected dry spell and hot summer could worsen the conflict, necessitating urgent measures.
4. **Political and Social Dimensions:** The issue has political, social, and environmental implications, with criticism of the government's wildlife management.
5. **Culling Demands:** Groups like KIFA and some church sections advocate for culling wildlife, citing a perceived population boom, but Forest Department data refute this claim.
6. **Declining Wildlife Populations:** Wild elephant populations have decreased by 7%, and snakebite-related deaths have dropped significantly.
7. **Tribal Vulnerability:** Many victims are from tribal communities, traditionally skilled in coexisting with wildlife, highlighting a need for investigation.
8. **Habitat Fragmentation:** Fragmented elephant corridors and disrupted habitats force animals into human settlements.
9. **Anthropogenic Factors:** Unregulated tourism, cattle grazing, encroachments, and food waste dumping near forests worsen the conflict.
10. **Invasive Species:** Invasive plants like *Senna spectabilis* and monoculture plantations disrupt wildlife feeding patterns.
11. **Government Measures:** Kerala empowered local bodies to address wild boar issues and classified human-wildlife conflict as a State-specific disaster.
12. **Participatory Management:** Emphasizing participatory forest and wildlife management is a positive step toward conflict resolution.
13. **Restoration Efforts:** The Forest Department has restored 5,031 hectares of natural forest and built water sources, but industrial plantations remain a challenge.
14. **Infrastructure Projects:** Solar fencing and elephant-proof walls are being implemented, but progress is slow.
15. **Multi-Agency Approach:** A coordinated effort involving multiple departments is essential to balance human safety and sustainable wildlife management.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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